

When is a suspension not a suspension?

The harmonic effect is the same for both the musical examples shown here, but in the first example, the shaded dissonance is an appoggiatura, a grace note that is played on the beat, or even slightly before it, lightly crushing into the consonance of the I–V progression.

▷ Suspended timing

Suspensions tend to behave like ornaments—their effect is passing. If the dissonance is prolonged, the sense of the key is threatened.

6–5 suspensions

Another common type of suspension is 6–5, where the dominant (V) is delayed. In the example shown here, the key signature has three flats, and the root is C in the final chord. This means that this is a C minor progression, not E♭ major. Thus, the chord in the middle, with the B in the bass, is a chord on the seventh degree of the scale, comprising B in the bass, D and F in the treble, with an added diminished seventh on the bass staff in the tenor part.

LOOKING CLOSER

Tristan chord

Richard Wagner's opera *Tristan und Isolde* derives much of its particular soundworld and feeling from the effect of the opening chord sequence. It has been analyzed in different ways, but it is essentially a chain of suspensions. Wagner does not resolve these suspensions until the end of the opera, so that all the music in between is heard in a state of expectation.

▷ *Tristan und Isolde*, opening

Since the first note is A, the second note, F, is a suspended sixth that creates the need to resolve on to the dominant of A, the E at the end of the first complete measure.